

Working from home — your VPN guide (1 page)

For: staff with approved remote access · **From:** IT · **Date:** 2026-10-02 **Read time:** 3 minutes · **Related:** `p06-network-access-policy.md`

What is changing

The old way of reaching Halden from home — a remote desktop link to the file server — has been removed. That link was reachable from the internet, which is how most ransomware gets into a company. It is replaced by a **VPN**: an encrypted connection you start yourself, with your normal work password **and an approval on your phone**.

Before you start

You need:

1. **An approved request.** Remote access is granted by your manager. If you have not been approved, contact IT — you cannot set this up yourself.
1. **Your work laptop** (not a personal device), fully updated.
2. **Your phone** with the authenticator app (Microsoft Authenticator, or the code app your setup e-mail tells you to use).
1. **The setup e-mail from IT**, which contains your personal VPN profile file. This file is unique to you. **Do not share it with anyone**, including colleagues.

Setting it up (about 5 minutes, once)

1. Save the profile file from IT's e-mail. It ends in `.ovpn`.
2. Install the VPN client: on Windows, install **OpenVPN Connect** from the Microsoft Store (IT will tell you if the lab uses a different client).
1. Open OpenVPN Connect and import the profile: **Import Profile** → **File** → choose the `.ovpn` file you saved.
1. Connect once. You will be asked for your **work username and password**, and then for an **approval on your phone**, or a **6-digit code** from your authenticator app.
1. You are connected when the client shows **Connected** and a green tunnel indicator.

Connecting to work each day

1. Open the VPN client and press **Connect**.
2. Enter your work username and password.
3. Approve the sign-in prompt on your phone (or enter the 6-digit code).
4. Open your files the usual way — `\\fs01.ad.halden.internal\Company` or your mapped drive letters.

The connection stays up while you work. When you finish for the day, press **Disconnect**.

What you can reach, and what you cannot

You can	You cannot
Open the company file shares you normally use	Reach IT's administration systems (by design — those are not available remotely)
Use the service desk portal	Use another person's profile or certificate
Work exactly as you would in the office for your own files	Connect from a personal or shared computer

Common problems

Problem	What to do
"Authentication failed"	Check the password; three failures locks your account. If it still fails, call the service desk — do not keep trying
No approval prompt appears on your phone	Check you have internet on the phone; open the authenticator app manually; if it still does not appear, use the 6-digit code instead
"Certificate error" or "profile invalid"	Your profile is either missing or has been revoked. Contact IT for a new one
Connected, but no drives appear	Sign out of Windows and back in once (drive letters are applied at sign-in). If they still do not appear, raise a ticket
File access is slow	Check your home internet speed first. If it is fine, raise a ticket: the cause may be a path being taken the long way around
You lost your laptop, or think someone has your profile	Tell IT immediately. The profile can be cancelled and the certificate revoked so it cannot be used again

Your responsibilities

- Keep your laptop updated and your password to yourself.
- Do not share your profile file, and do not copy it to another computer.
- Use the VPN only for work.
- Report anything unusual — an unexpected approval prompt you did not trigger, for example. An unexpected MFA prompt means someone else has your password, and that is urgent.

If you no longer need remote access

Tell your manager. Access is reviewed every quarter and removed when it is no longer needed — that is a feature, not a punishment: an account nobody uses but everybody can use is a way in.

Who to contact

Situation	Contact
Cannot connect, forgot which app to use	IT service desk (ticket)
Suspect your password or phone has been compromised	IT service desk immediately , by phone, marked urgent
Need remote access for the first time	Your manager, then IT on the approved request

Halden Distribution Ltd. is a fictional company; this guide is a portfolio artefact. The technical controls it describes are real, and no measured result is claimed anywhere in it.